

NINTH ROUND Gov. Arlekar with Nitish Kumar and deputy CMs Samrat Chaudhary and Vijay Kumar Sinha at the swearing-in, Jan. 28

NITISH'S REDUCED CLOUT IS EVIDENT FROM THE BJP'S CHOICE OF DEPUTY CHIEF MINISTERS—BOTH STRIDENT CRITICS OF THE CM IN THE PAST

The hammer fell on January 28, as Nitish resigned and took oath again as chief minister for a record ninth time, returning to the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance, which he had left just 18 months before. This is the third government formed after the assembly polls in October-November 2020. The CM said his split from the RJD-Congress alliance—for the second time in seven years—was based on the feedback from his JD(U) legislators.

A total of eight ministers, including two deputy CMs from the BJP, Samrat Choudhary and Vijay Kumar Sinha, were also sworn in. The choice of deputies also tells a tale—both have been strident Nitish critics in the past. Choudhary, in fact, had vowed in 2022 after the JD(U) chief dumped the BJP that he would not take off his turban till Nitish was "dethroned". While Sinha is a Bhumihar, one of Bihar's dominant castes, Choudhary is a Kushwaha through whom the BJP may also be eyeing Nitish's famous Luv-Kush (Kurmi-Kushwaha) vote bank. And though it has only been days, it's clear that the JD(U) chief doesn't carry the old clout; already, a few BJP leaders have started talking about enforcing the Yogi model of governance in Bihar. Nitish's new government is also supported by Jitan Ram Manjhi's Hindustani Awam Morcha (Secular) or HAM(S) and its four MLAs. The three parties together have 127 MLAs in the house of 243 (just barely above the 122 halfway mark).

Despite the "*aaya-ram, gaya-ram*" and "Paltiputra" barbs Nitish attracted for his latest about-turn, there is no denying that he is a survivor par excellence. Right now, the configuration of the Bihar assembly is such that though Nitish's 45-MLA JD(U) is third in the pecking order—RJD has 79 and BJP 78 MLAs—no government is possible without